JAPAN MARKET ENTRY

The Japan Entry Sequence

Why overseas teams don't fail on the requirements.
They fail on the **order** — and rebuild what they already paid for.

0	**Classification**	before anything
1	**Route**	entity, permits, money
2	**Trust surface**	what buyers check
3	**Language**	not first
4	**Demand & operations**	last

A FIELD GUIDE · 12 PAGES

SAVE THIS

Japan entry is not a checklist. It's a dependency graph.

Every overseas team I meet has a list. Translate the site. Set up payments. Find a distributor. Incorporate, maybe.

The list is rarely wrong. The **sequence** almost always is.

Each step in a Japan launch has preconditions. Do it before its preconditions are settled and the work isn't merely early — it becomes work you will do twice.

> WHAT THIS ACTUALLY MEANS
>
> The dominant failure mode isn't skipping a requirement. It's completing requirements in an order that guarantees rework. Teams don't discover this until the invoice for the second attempt arrives.

GATE ZERO

0 Classification

What are you selling — under Japanese law, not under your marketing category?

These are not the same question, and the gap is where launches break.

- A "supplement" may sit in food, or in a regulated category with advertising restrictions you cannot design around.
- A "smart skincare device" can be a cosmetic, an electrical appliance, and radio equipment — three separate regimes, at once.
- A "token" may be treated as crypto-assets, as prepaid payment instruments, or as securities. Different regulators. Different answers.

> **IF YOU SKIP IT**
>
> Classification sits upstream of everything. Get it wrong and Gates 1 through 4 are built on a foundation that has to be replaced — not adjusted.

1

GATE ONE

Route

How do goods, money, and legal responsibility physically enter Japan?

- Do you need a Japanese entity — or do you only think you do?
- Who is the importer of record, and are they permitted to be?
- Which permits attach to a person, and which attach to a company?
- Where does the money land, and who is liable for the tax on it?

THE INSIGHT MOST TEAMS PAY TO LEARN

The entity question is **downstream** of the permit question, not upstream. Teams incorporate first because incorporating feels like progress — then find the permit requires a different structure, or that the entity was never needed at all.

IF YOU SKIP IT

An unnecessary Japanese entity is not a one-time mistake. It is a permanent annual cost: filings, accounting, a resident officer, and a dissolution bill if you ever unwind it.

2

GATE TWO

Trust surface

Everything a Japanese buyer checks before they will consider your offer at all.

- The legally required commercial disclosure — present, complete, in Japanese
- A domestic address and a domestic phone number
- Payment methods beyond the card you assume everyone uses
- A delivery promise stated in days, not in ranges
- A return policy that exists, in writing, before purchase
- Support hours in JST — while the buyer is awake

> WHY YOUR TRANSLATED PAGE DIDN'T CONVERT
>
> Western landing pages are engineered to maximise desire. Japanese buyers run a **risk-elimination pass first** — they look for reasons not to buy before they evaluate reasons to buy. A single hole in the trust surface ends the visit, and no amount of persuasive copy reaches the buyer after that point.

3

GATE THREE

Language

The step almost every team does first — and the one that belongs here.

Translation is the cheapest, most legible, most purchasable step in the entire sequence. It is the only part of Japan entry that arrives with a per-word price and a delivery date.

So teams buy it first. Not because it comes first — because it is the only thing they know how to buy.

> **THE TRAP**
>
> Translating before Gates 0–2 means translating pages whose claims, structure, disclosures, and checkout are all still going to change. You are not buying language. You are buying a draft.

> **AND ONE MORE THING**
>
> Regulated categories constrain what you are permitted to *claim*. A faithful translation of a compliant English claim can be a non-compliant Japanese one.

4

GATE FOUR

Demand & operations

Channel, acquisition, sales motion, support. The part everyone wanted to start with.

- Marketplace, own store, or partner — each carries a different fee structure and a different amount of control you give up permanently
- Whether your sales motion survives contact with a consensus-based buying process
- Who answers a Japanese customer at 3pm on a Tuesday, in Japanese
- What you will measure in the first 30 days, decided **before** the first 30 days

WHY IT GOES LAST

Demand generation is the only gate that produces revenue, which is exactly why it gets pulled forward. But spend applied before Gates 0–2 are settled does not buy learning. It buys traffic to a surface that cannot convert, and then teaches you the wrong lesson about Japanese demand.

What has to be true before each step

0. **Classification**
   Requires: nothing. Start here, always.

1. **Route**
   Requires: a settled regulatory category

2. **Trust surface**
   Requires: a legal entity path, a domestic address, a payment route

3. **Language**
   Requires: final claims, final disclosures, final checkout

4. **Demand & operations**
   Requires: a surface that can convert and a team that can answer

FAILURE PATTERNS

The four order errors

DONE TOO EARLY	DEPENDS ON	WHAT IT COSTS
Incorporating in Japan	Which permits attach to which structure	Permanent annual cost for an entity you may not need
Translating the site	Final claims and disclosures	Paid twice; the second version is the real one
Signing a distributor	Knowing what your channel is worth	Terms set before you had any leverage — and they persist
Running paid acquisition	A surface that can actually convert	Spend, plus a false conclusion about Japanese demand

> NOTE
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> Every one of these is a **competent** action. That is what makes the pattern hard to see from inside: nothing looks like a mistake while it is happening.

Rework isn't additive.

A wrong answer at Gate 0 doesn't cost you Gate 0. It costs you everything built on top of it.

- Re-classify the product → the permit path changes
- The permit path changes → the entity decision may reverse
- The entity changes → the disclosure page, the invoicing, and the payment route all change
- Those change → the translated pages are stale
- Stale pages → the acquisition spend was aimed at a surface that no longer exists

> **THE REAL NUMBER**
>
> The money is rarely what kills the project. It is the second calendar year. A Japan launch that has to be rebuilt tends to lose its internal sponsor before it loses its budget — and a project without a sponsor does not get a third attempt.

THE HONEST PART

When the answer is "not yet"

Japan is a good market. It is not a good market for every company in every quarter. Three conditions where I would tell you to wait:

- **You have no empowered approver.**
  If every decision has to travel back to a committee overseas, the launch will stall in the gaps, not in the work.
- **Your core product is still moving weekly.**
  Japan rewards a stable, well-explained offer. Localising a product that changes shape every sprint means localising it repeatedly.
- **You cannot answer a Japanese customer within one business day.**
  Not perfectly, not in fluent Japanese — but reliably. Without that, the trust surface leaks faster than acquisition can fill it.

> WHY SAY THIS AT ALL
>
> Entering Japan badly is worse than entering late. A failed launch teaches your organisation that Japan doesn't work — and that belief outlives everyone who was in the room.

WHERE TO START

If you're planning a Japan launch, start at Gate 0 — even if it feels like going backwards.

Classification takes days. Rebuilding a launch takes quarters. Almost every expensive Japan entry I have seen was expensive because the sequence ran in the order that felt most productive, rather than the order the dependencies allowed.

Tell me which gate you're standing at.
I'll tell you what usually breaks next.
